

She and her husband, a successful cotton farmer, arrived at our house on Friday. They were driving a late-model Nissan Maxima. The automobile appeared to be in excellent condition. Shopper Four drove her husband and me around the community for about twenty minutes, test-driving the Acura. During that time I had a chance to debrief them. Why did they drive all the way from cotton country? Why were they interested in buying a used vehicle? Aren't farmers supposed to be frugal?

It seems that this couple shops for a late-model, quality, used Japanese vehicle every two or three years. They find the prices and availability significantly better in the big city. (They are nearly 150 miles from the nearest Acura dealer.) They buy cars like mine and resell them in two or three years in their rural community for close to what they paid for them.

Shopper Four and her husband convinced me that they were frugal. They arrived with a certified check in an amount that was \$1,000 less than my asking price. The farmer, upon returning from the test drive, asked his wife, "Aren't you going to try to negotiate with this guy?" She, in turn, said, "This fellow doesn't need to sell this car. And it's in great condition." Her husband agreed. Thereupon, she handed me the certified check and ten \$100 bills. After all the papers were signed and the deal was complete, she told me that my car sold for at least \$3,000 more at the dealer nearest her farm. I responded that her colleagues would likely be impressed with this car when she drove up to school on Monday. Her husband commented that the other teachers would really be impressed if they knew how little she had paid for it.

One comment he made was of particular interest to me: "My wife works with a woman who drives a new, comparably equipped MercedesBenz. She leased it for sixty months, \$600 per month. Do you know how much cotton you have to grow to make those payments?"

A PROFESSOR OF THRIFT HAS UAWs FOR NEIGHBORS

How did Dr. Bill, an engineering professor who never had a total household income of more than \$80,000, become a millionaire? He inherited nothing. He never won the lottery or hired an investment advisor who turned a few thousand of his dollars into a fortune. His success in accumulating wealth is based on living well below his means. This professor is a classic example of a used vehicle-prone shopper. But